

British Aerospace/Aérospatiale Concorde



THERE WAS ARGUABLY NOTHING quite as remarkable in the history of flight as a Concorde scheduled service, which saw over 100 passengers—without flying suits or helmets—traveling 11 miles (17.7 km) above the Earth. They moved faster than a rifle bullet—yet, as a journalist observed, their coffee, “moving a mile every 2.7 seconds, doesn’t even ripple.”

When the French and British governments signed an agreement to design and produce a supersonic transport in 1962, they were convinced that the future of passenger aviation lay in ever-increasing speed and shorter journey times. The challenge was to produce an airliner that could cruise at Mach 2—a speed only achieved by fighter aircraft for brief periods. Much ingenuity went into the task of designing Concorde. For example, because the craft flew steeply (tail-down) during take-off and landing, the pilots would not have been able to see forward in a conventional plane. This difficulty was overcome by hinging the nose to drop during these phases of the flight. The nose was raised hydraulically for supersonic flight and a visor lifted to streamline it to the windshield.

“It is not unreasonable to look upon Concorde as a miracle.”

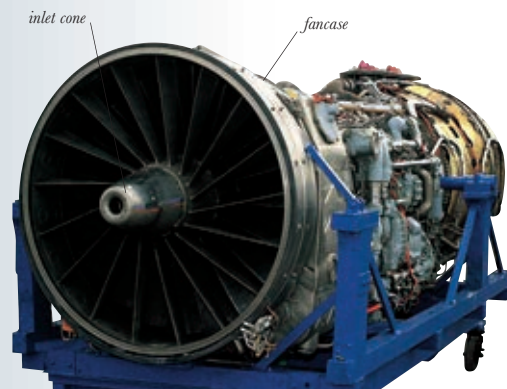
BRIAN TRUBSHAW
CONCORDE TEST PILOT

The first prototype did not fly until March 1969; the first production aircraft appeared in 1973. Air France and British Airways put their first Concorde into service on the same day in 1976. But by then conditions for the launch of a supersonic airliner were abysmal. Attacks from the ecological lobby (responding to the threat of high levels of pollution and noise) meant that Concorde was banned from many of the world’s airports. Spiraling fuel prices also deterred prospective buyers. As a result, only 16 production Concorde were built. Yet Concorde did establish its niche as a luxury or once-in-a-lifetime experience. And many agree with pilot Christopher Orlebar, who described Concorde as “an engineering dream, a beautiful aircraft, way ahead of anything... conceived since.”



PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

An engineer is seen working on the forward fuselage of the 002 Concorde prototype, in 1968. The 002 was the first Concorde assembled in Britain.



AIRFLOW CONTROL

Concorde was powered by four Rolls-Royce/SNECMA Olympus turbojet engines. An ingenious feature of these engines was that no matter how fast the craft was moving, the speed of airflow to the engines remained less than 300 mph (483 kph).

